

Six ways to feel at home

*Visual directions for a note-taking app — old-fashioned, warm, stylish,
and quietly modern.*

The brief, as I read it. Not retro-computing. Nothing grey, boxy or institutional. The reference points are **analog and tactile** — paper, ink, cloth, leather, wood — the objects people actually kept notes in before apps existed.

Every direction below follows four rules: warm paper-tone backgrounds instead of white or grey; one saturated accent, used sparingly; a real typographic voice with a serif or typewriter face for body text; and softness in the details — small radii, hairline rules, gentle shadows, no hard chrome.

“A bit modern” shows up as restraint rather than pastiche: generous spacing, a clear type hierarchy, and modern interaction comfort. The result should read as a well-made object, not a costume.



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Kraft & Ink

The pocket field notebook — kraft cover, dot-grid paper, a rubber-stamped label and ink that looks pressed into the page.



PALETTE



#B08A57 kraft #EDE3CE paper
#F7F0E1 card #22303F ink #9C4A33 brick
#8A7C64 dim

TYPE

Notebook

Measure the alcove before
ordering shelves.

Futura · Courier

Feels like the notebook already in your back pocket — worn, unprecious, the one you don't mind writing a shopping list in.

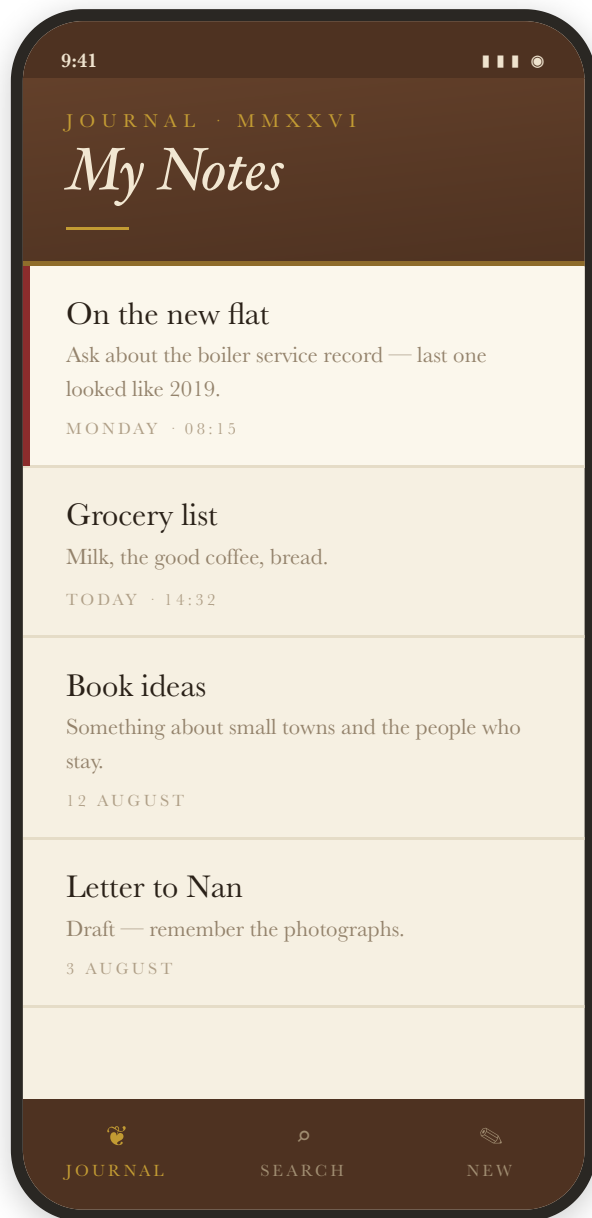
THE IDEA

Utilitarian but affectionate. The kraft header is the **cover**; scroll and you're on the dot-grid **page**. Notes sit as slightly raised cards so the list feels like loose leaves tucked inside.

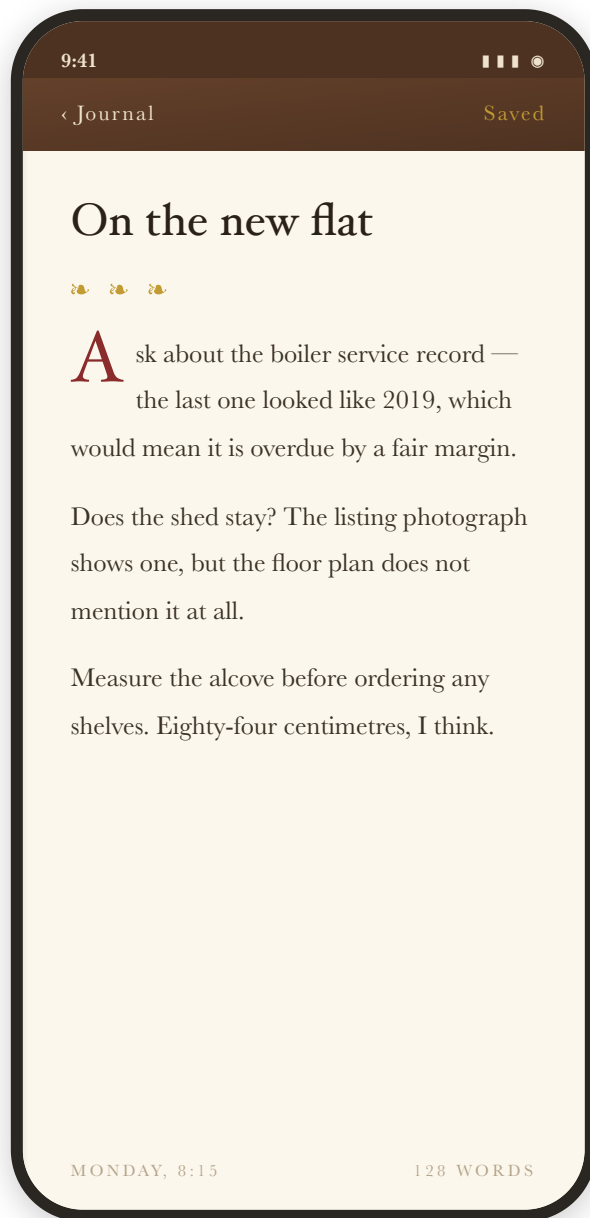
Body copy in a typewriter mono keeps it honest and unfussy, while Futura in the chrome does the modern work — geometric, clean, no nostalgia tax.

Leather & Cream

The kept journal — espresso hide, gilded edges, a crimson ribbon marking your place and a proper serif on cream stock.

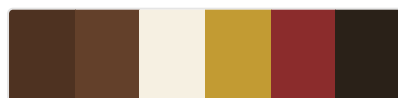


LIST



EDITOR

PALETTE



#4E3221 hide #63402A hide lt
#F6F0E2 cream #C29B33 gold
#8B2C2C ribbon #2A2118 ink

TYPE

My Notes

Does the shed stay? The floor plan does not say.

Hoefer Text · Baskerville

Feels like the hardbound notebook someone gave you as a gift — the one you hesitate to write the first page in.

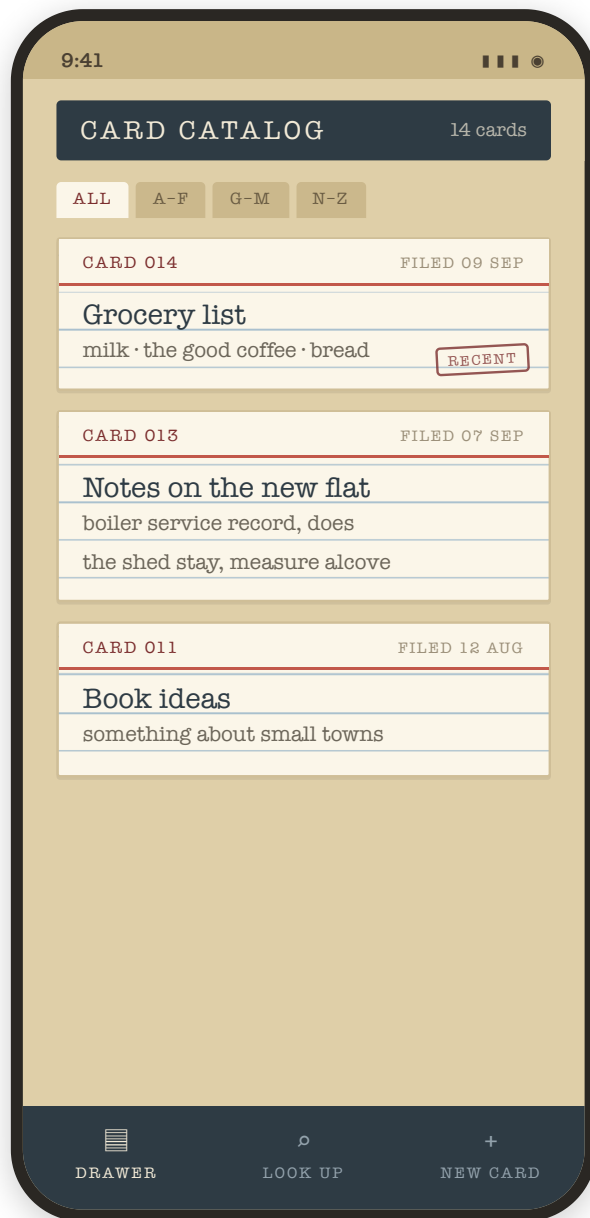
THE IDEA

The most **premium and personal** of the six. The dark hide header frames cream pages; gold hairlines do all the accenting; the crimson ribbon replaces any modern highlight state.

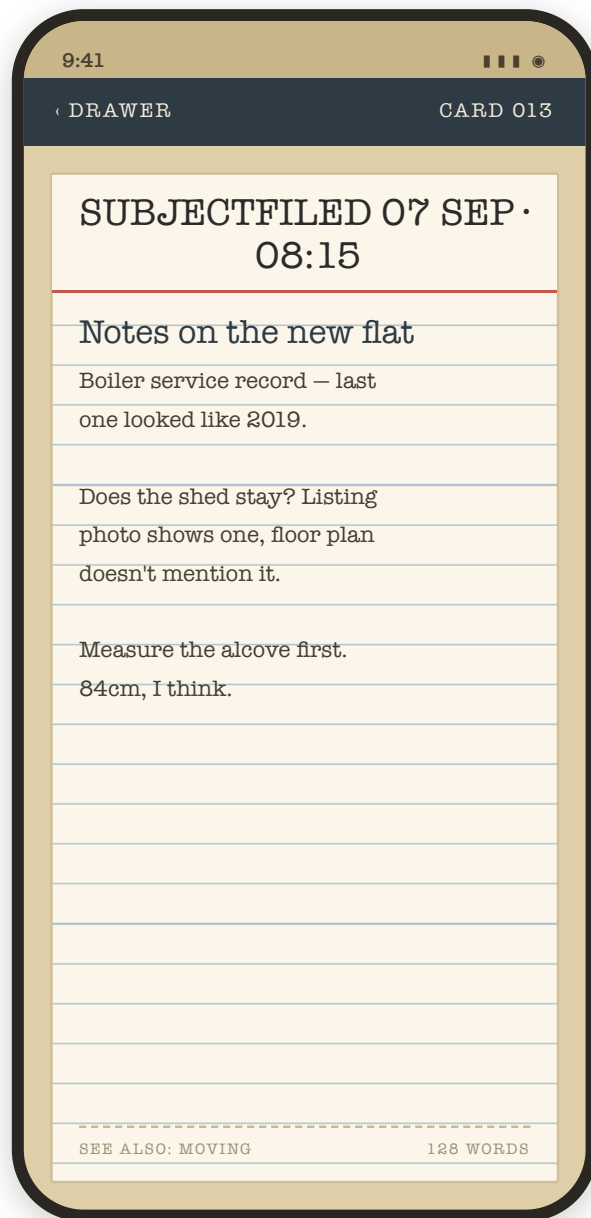
A drop cap and a small ornament give each entry the dignity of a page in a real journal — which quietly encourages longer, more thoughtful writing.

Card Catalog

The library drawer — manila index cards, a red rule under the header, blue faint lines and a date stamp in oxblood ink.



LIST



EDITOR

PALETTE



#DFCFA8 manila #F8F6E9 card
 #2E3B44 ink #7B2E2E oxblood
 #C2584A red rule #A9C0CE feint

TYPE

Card Catalog

Filed 07 Sep · see also: moving

American Typewriter throughout

Feels like the wooden drawer at a small-town library — slightly musty, entirely trustworthy, everything findable.

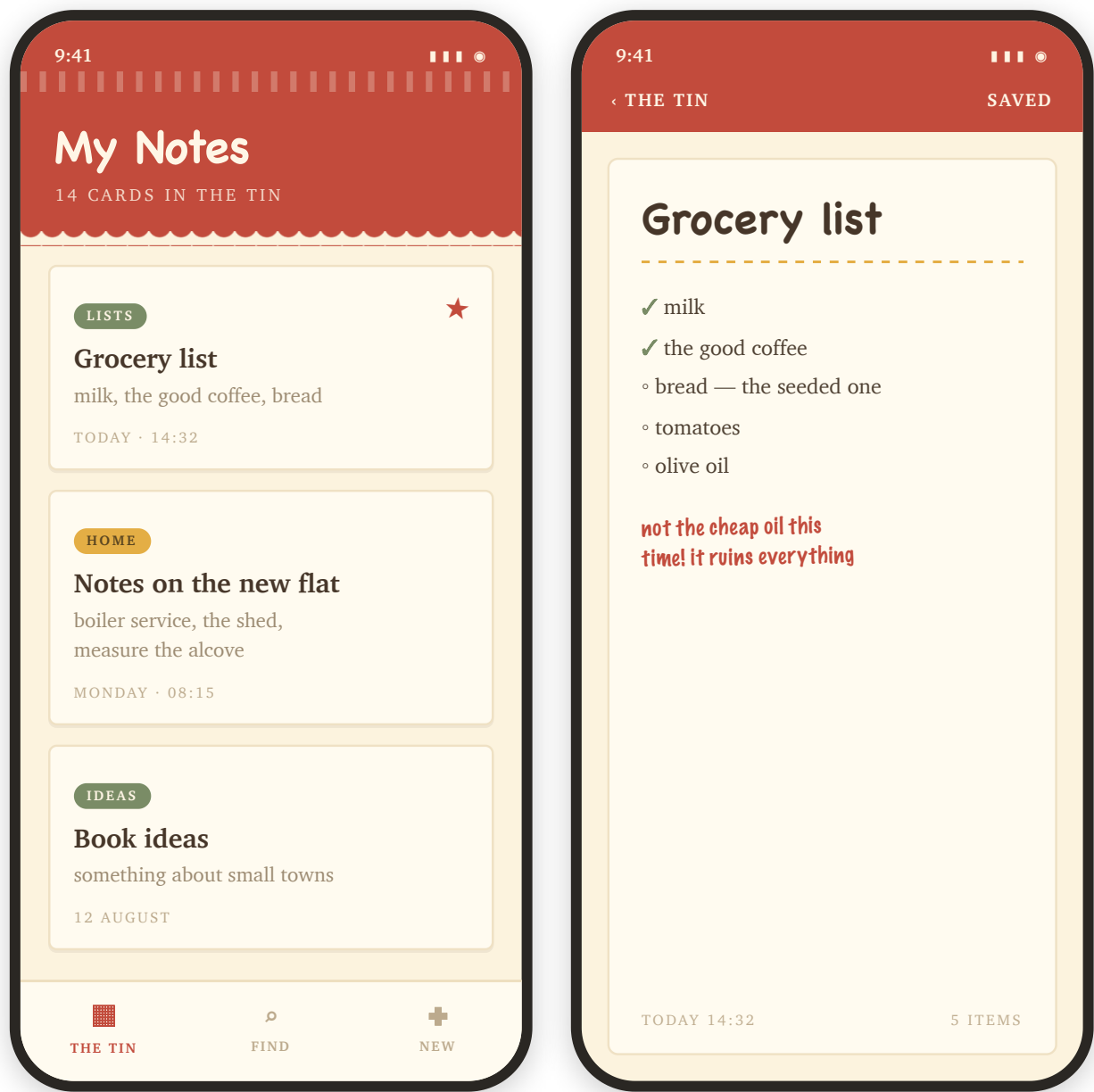
THE IDEA

The one with a real **organising metaphor** built in — cards, drawers, alphabet tabs, “see also”. Structure comes for free, which suits a notes app that might grow tags or folders later.

Ruled faint lines behind the text and a red rule under each header do the heavy lifting; the typewriter face is used at every size, so the whole thing holds together with one font.

Recipe Tin

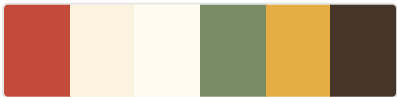
The kitchen index box — ticking stripe, tomato red, sage and butter, with a handwritten margin note in the corner.



LIST

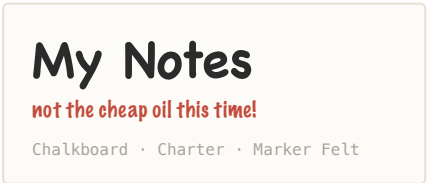
EDITOR

PALETTE



#C24B3C tomato #FCF3DE cream
#FFFBF0 card #7A8C66 sage
#E4AE45 butter #463629 cocoa

TYPE



Feels like your grandmother's recipe box on the counter — splattered, annotated, unmistakably lived in.

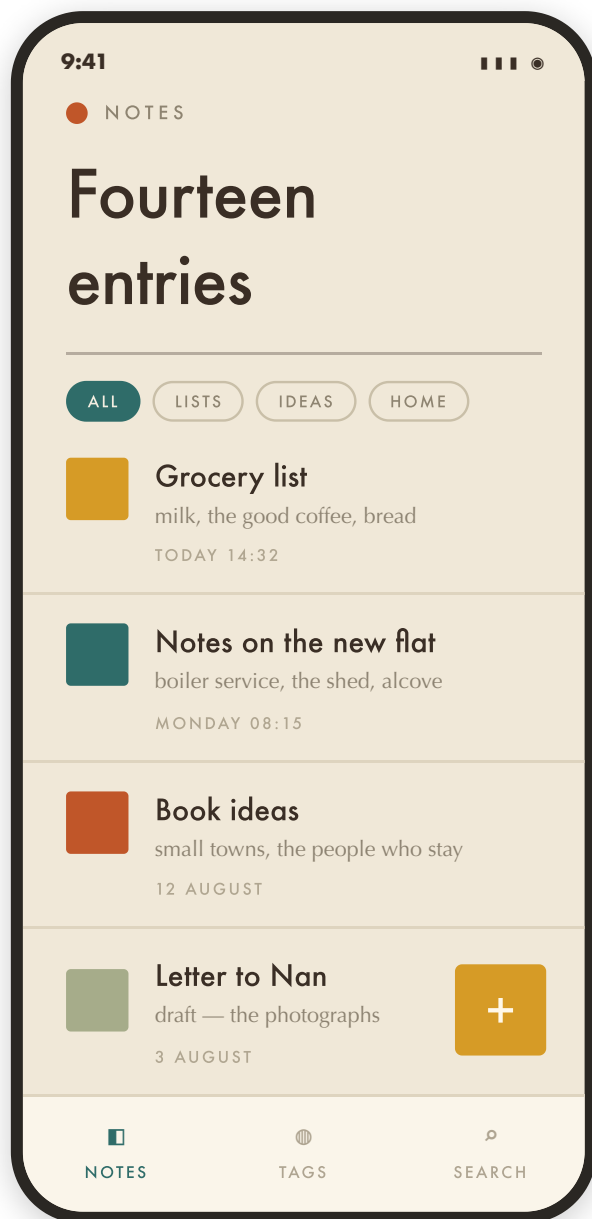
THE IDEA

The **warmest and most domestic** option, and the most literal reading of “feel at home”. Colour-coded category pills, scalloped card edges, and a handwriting face reserved strictly for margin notes.

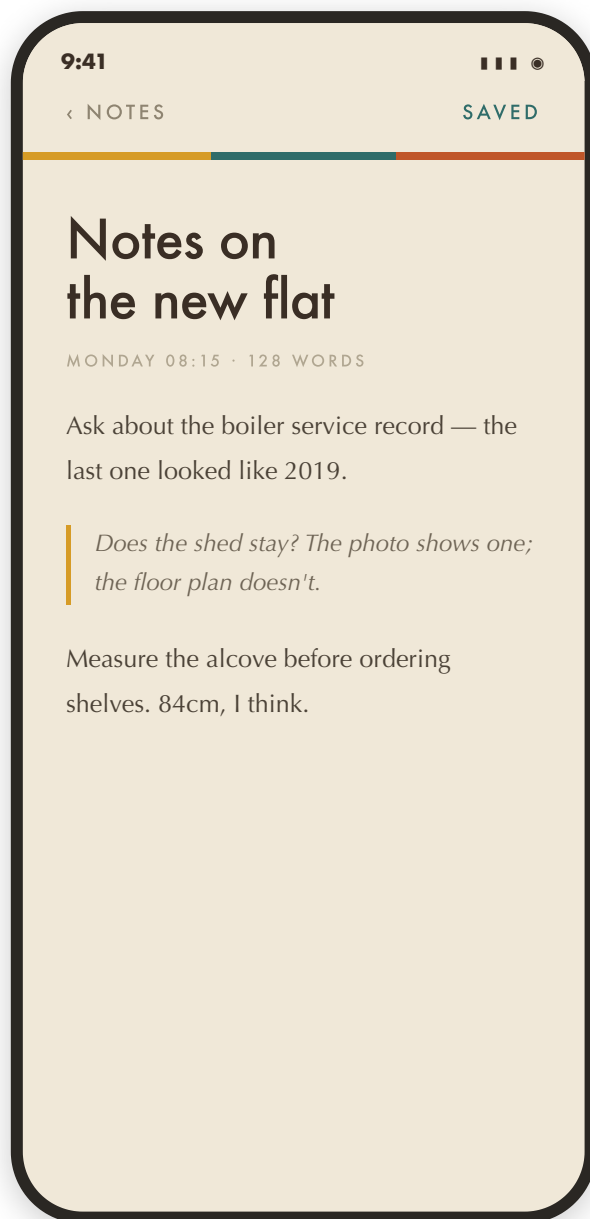
Worth knowing: the handwriting font is the risk. Used for one accent per screen it's charming; used for body text it becomes a novelty app fast. I'd cap it hard.

Mid-century Stationery

The 1962 desk set — bone paper, mustard, teal and burnt orange, hairline rules and a great deal of quiet space.



LIST



EDITOR

PALETTE



#F0E8D8 bone #D69B26 mustard
 #2F6C69 teal #C05629 orange
 #A6AC8A sage #3A2E25 walnut

TYPE

Fourteen entries

Measure the alcove before ordering shelves.

Futura · Optima

Feels like a well-kept writing desk — the good pen, the nice paper, everything squared up and to hand.

THE IDEA

The **most modern-feeling** of the six while still being unmistakably of another era. Warmth comes from the palette and the bone paper rather than from texture, so it stays crisp and very legible.

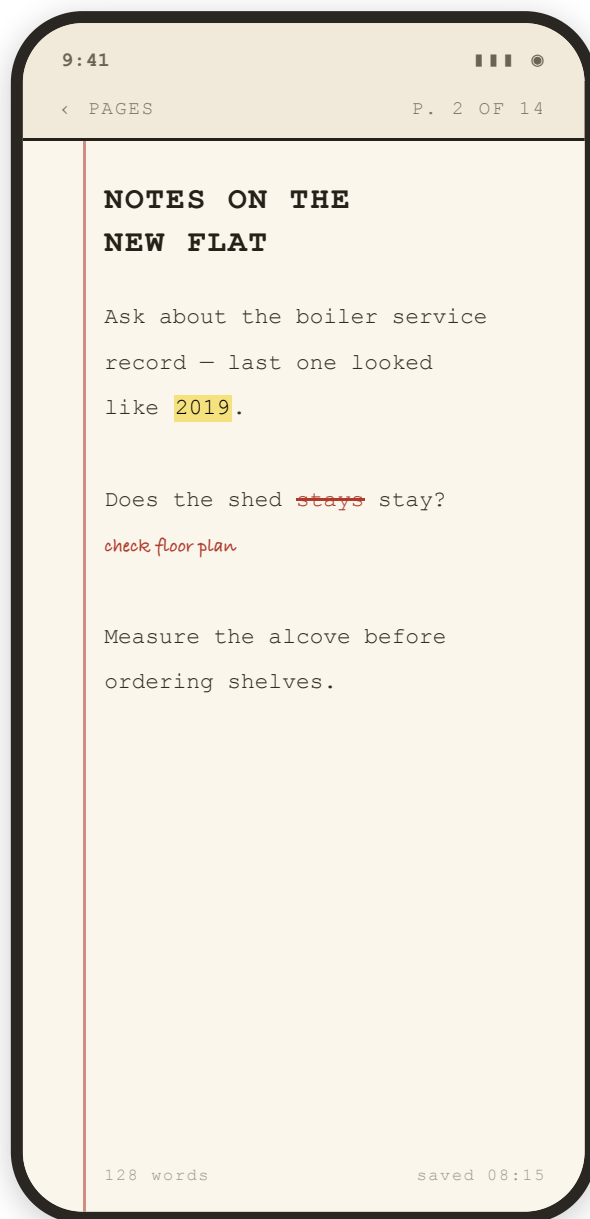
Colour-coded squares carry categories, hairline rules replace card borders, and the three-colour bar is the only flourish. Also the easiest to build and the easiest to keep consistent as the app grows.

Manuscript

The typewriter page — onion-skin stock, carbon-black Courier, a red margin rule and edits in pencil.



LIST



EDITOR

PALETTE



#F1EADA onion #FAF6EC page
 #252119 carbon #AF3A2C pencil
 #5A6B7C faded blue #F5E27F marker

TYPE

MANUSCRIPT

Does the shed stay? — check
 floor plan

Courier · Bradley Hand for edits

Feels like a half-finished draft left in the typewriter — the one you keep coming back to.

THE IDEA

The **writer's** option. Everything is a page: numbered, word-counted, with a red margin rule and generous line spacing that makes long-form typing genuinely pleasant.

Its trick is treating edit history as visible craft — strikethroughs in red pencil, insertions in handwriting, highlighter for the bit you're unsure about. Beautiful, and the narrowest in appeal: monospace body text is a real acquired taste on a phone.

Where I'd land

All six meet the brief. They differ in how loud the costume is, and in how well they'll hold up once the app has features.

DIRECTION	WARMTH	MODERN	EFFORT	BEST IF...
● Kraft & Ink	High	Medium	Low	you want everyday, unprecious, quick-capture notes.
● Leather & Cream	High	Low	Medium	notes are long-form and personal — a journal more than a scratchpad.
● Card Catalog	Medium	Low	Medium	organisation matters and you expect tags, folders, cross-references.
● Recipe Tin	Highest	Medium	Medium	you want the friendliest, most domestic feel and don't mind whimsy.
● Mid-century	Medium	High	Lowest	you want it to age well and stay legible as features pile up.
● Manuscript	Medium	Low	Low	the app is for writing drafts, not lists.

RECOMMENDATION

Kraft & Ink, with two details borrowed from elsewhere: the **mid-century colour-coded squares** for categories, and the **manuscript red margin rule** in the editor.

It hits every word of the brief without tipping into pastiche. Kraft and dot-grid paper give real warmth; Futura in the chrome supplies the modern edge; the typewriter body face stays old-fashioned where it counts, in the writing itself. It also has the fewest ways to go wrong — no handwriting font to over-use, no dark leather to fight for contrast, no monospace tax on readability.

If you want warmer, take **Recipe Tin**. If you want it to look sharp for a decade, take **Mid-century**. Those are the two I'd argue for after my own pick.

WHAT I STILL NEED FROM YOU

1. **Which direction** — or a hybrid, if a specific pairing appeals more than any single page.
2. **What kind of notes** is this really for: quick lists and capture, or longer writing? It changes the editor completely, and it changes which of these six is right.
3. **Platforms** — iOS only, or do web and Android matter? All six work on the web, but bundled fonts and paper textures cost more there.
4. **Dark mode** — I'd skip it for v1. Every one of these is built on warm paper, and the inversions are a design project of their own.